



KETAN MHATRE, 33
Patient Of: Rheumatoid Arthritis
Treatment: Hip resurfacing and knee joint replacement

This software developer was diagnosed with arthritis at the age of 23. He was under severe work pressure and was working and eating at irregular hours—habits that, he believes, could have triggered arthritis. In the last few years, his condition deteriorated rapidly and he could not even walk up the stairs or sit on the floor. "I used to scream continuously for two hours because the pain in my legs was so severe. I could hear my hips cracking when I moved," he says. For six months he relied on crutches because his knees were bent at 60 degrees. His biggest fear was that he would lose his job as his performance dropped. Now, after surgery in October 2009, he can climb stairs again, albeit with a limp. He has even bagged four awards from his company for his performance.

DR KAUSHAL MALHAN
 EXAMINING MHATRE

KEEP THE PAIN AT BAY

You can prevent it with some minor changes in your lifestyle

- If you get joint pains, seek medical opinion immediately.
- Eat fruits and vegetables. Avoid fatty, high-calorie saturated foods.
- Do regular exercises like stretching, walking and swimming.
- Avoid smoking and keep alcohol intake to a minimum.
- If there's an early detection of arthritis, avoid strenuous exercises like jogging and tennis.
- Eat prescribed food supplements.
- If your parents or grandparents have arthritis, you should go for an annual check-up to your doctor.

TRIPLE TROUBLE FOR THE YOUNG

Women are more likely to get affected by osteoarthritis and hypertension

	25-35 years	Men	Women
OSTEOARTHRITIS	2.7	1	3.9
HYPERTENSION	1.3	0.4	1.9
DIABETES	1.1	1.5	0.8

Figures in per cent; source: TNS Arogya 2006: The Health Monitor

sociated with Ram Lal Kundan Lal Orthopedic Hospital in Delhi. It's not only about physical fitness and the quantum of exercise the body gets, but a poor diet is a major contributor to arthritis. As they say, you are what you eat. Fatty, high cholesterol foods contain molecules (free radicals) that cause tissue damage. With youngsters steering clear of fruits and vegetables, they are denying their bodies antioxidants that neutralise these toxic free radicals. It is well-established that smoking has a direct link with rheumatoid arthritis. Even pollution sets off chemical reactions in the body that trigger it. "Anxiety and stress play a big part in rheumatoid arthritis and today's youngsters are under a lot of

stress," says Dr Rahul Shah, who is associated with Bhatia Hospital and Saifee Hospital in Mumbai.

Rampant binge drinking among the young in the metros is the number one cause for the trend, according to Dr Sharma. He says if someone is consuming more than the prescribed limit of alcohol, which is 30 ml in three days, it will lead to a thinning of the cartilage. "Alcohol metabolises through the liver and the liver has got enzymes which are important for bone and cartilage preservation," says Sharma. Although the alarm bells are ringing in the medical community, most people are oblivious to the disease. This is partly because it does not have the same shock factor as diabetes or heart

disease and partly because the symptoms don't seem so severe at first. Most young patients will start to develop mild joint pains that are easy to ignore and will let the disease get worse before seeking treatment. Doctors say that youngsters should go for treatment earlier, rather than waiting for it to worsen. The medical fraternity is also finding ways to cope with this new trend. In a young patient, a knee or hip replacement needs to cause minimal damage to the tissue and bone as they are likely to outlive the life of their new joint. They'll probably need another joint revision unlike an elderly person. There are surgeries using a tissue sparing technique, which reaches the joint without cutting the muscle of the thigh, ensuring faster recovery and less damage. There are also hip resurfacing implants that allow a high range of bending due to their design.

It's well known that young India is caving in to all types of pressures, from stress to obesity. While youngsters are in fear of ending up with diabetes and heart disease like their parents and grandparents, arthritis is becoming a bigger pain that should be feared the most. It's coming much sooner than expected. ■